

Han Kang, First South Korean Writer to Win Nobel in Literature

South Korean writer Han Kang won the 2024 Nobel Prize in Literature on Thursday. The Swedish Academy's Nobel Committee said her work "confronts historical traumas and exposes the fragility of human life."

Born in 1970, Han Kang is the first South Korean to win the literature prize. Kang began her career in 1993 with the publication of several poems in *Literature and Society*. She published her first story in 1995 with *Love of Yeosu*.

In 2016, Kang won the Man Booker International Prize for *The Vegetarian*. It tells the story of a woman's decision to stop eating meat and her family's worry about her mental health. The novel was the first of her books to be translated into English and was seen as her major international breakthrough.

In a talk with the Booker Prizes, published last year, Kang said the book was written during a difficult period in her life. She questioned whether she could finish the story or even survive as a writer.

"I was suffering from severe arthritis...To this day, I feel awkward when I hear about the novel's 'success,'" she said.

In the novel *Human Acts*, Kang explored the 1980 killing of hundreds of students and unarmed civilians by the South Korean military in the city of Gwangju, where she grew up.

"In seeking to give voice to the victims of history, the book confronts this episode with brutal actualization and, in so doing, approaches the genre of witness literature," the Academy said.

Books by South Korean writer Han Kang are displayed in the Swedish Academy after she was named the 2024 laureate of the Nobel Prize in Literature in Stockholm, Sweden, October 10, 2024. (REUTERS/Tom Little)

One of two South Korean Nobel winners

Kang is the second South Korean to win a Nobel Prize. Former South Korean President Kim Dae-jung received the Nobel Peace Prize in 2000 for his efforts to restore democracy in the South and improve relations with North Korea.

The literature prize has long faced criticism that it is too centered on European and North American writings. It has also been awarded mainly to male writers. Kang is only the 18th

woman to receive the award among more than 100 winners.

Past winners of the prize include well-known writers like Irish poet W.B. Yeats, American writer Ernest Hemingway and Colombia's Gabriel Garcia Marquez. In 2016, American singer Bob Dylan also received the prize “for having created new poetic expressions within the great American song tradition”

Mats Malm is Permanent Secretary of the Swedish Academy. He told reporters, “I was able to talk to Han Kang over the phone. She was having an ordinary day, it seems, she had just finished supper with her son.”

The prize comes with a money award of \$1.1 million.

I’m Mario J. Ritter, Jr.

Jill Robbins adapted the story for Learning English based on reports from Reuters and The Associated Press.

Vocabulary

trauma - n. ประสบการณ์ที่ยากลำบากหรือไม่พึงประสงค์อย่างมากซึ่งทำให้เกิดปัญหาสุขภาพจิตหรืออารมณ์ซึ่งมักจะคงอยู่เป็นเวลานาน

fragile - adj. เปราะบาง แตกหักง่าย เสียหายง่าย

novel - n. นวนิยาย เรื่องเล่าขนาดยาวที่มักเกี่ยวกับตัวละครและเหตุการณ์ที่สมมติขึ้น

arthritis - n. โรคข้ออักเสบ โรคที่ทำให้ข้อต่อของร่างกายบวมและเจ็บปวด

brutal - adj. โหดร้าย ทารุณ ตรงไปตรงมาและแม่นยำในลักษณะที่รุนแรงหรือไม่น่าพึงพอใจ

genre - n. ประเภท ชนิด หรือหมวดหมู่เฉพาะของวรรณกรรมหรืองานศิลปะ

supper - n. อาหารมื้อเย็น โดยเฉพาะอย่างยิ่งหมายถึงอาหารมื้อไม่เป็นทางการที่รับประทานที่บ้าน

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. According to Paragraph 2, what is the primary reason the Swedish Academy awarded Han Kang the 2024 Nobel Prize in Literature?

Her groundbreaking use of surrealism in modern fiction.

Her ability to capture the essence of everyday South Korean life.

Her confrontation of historical traumas and exposure of human fragility.

Her unique contribution to the genre of witness literature.

2. What significant achievement is mentioned about Han Kang in relation to her South Korean identity?

She is the youngest South Korean to win a major international literary award.

She is the first South Korean woman to publish poems and stories internationally.

She is the first South Korean to win the Nobel Prize in Literature.

She is the most translated South Korean author in history.

3. When did Han Kang begin her career as a writer?

With her first story in 1995.

With the publication of several poems in 1993.

After winning the Man Booker International Prize in 2016.

Upon her birth in 1970.

4. For which novel did Han Kang win the Man Booker International Prize in 2016?

Human Acts

Love of Yeosu

Literature and Society

The Vegetarian

5. What was the main significance of *The Vegetarian* in Han Kang's career, as stated in Paragraph 4?

It was her most controversial work to date.

It earned her widespread critical acclaim within South Korea.

It served as her major international breakthrough after being translated into English.

It was the first book where she experimented with a vegan protagonist.

6. According to Han Kang, what were the circumstances surrounding the writing of *The Vegetarian*?

She wrote it during a period of immense creative inspiration.

It was completed quickly and without major challenges.

She wrote it during a difficult period and questioned her ability to finish it.

It was a collaborative effort with other international writers.

7. What specific physical ailment did Han Kang suffer from while writing *The Vegetarian*?

Severe headaches.

Chronic back pain.

Severe arthritis.

Repetitive strain injury.

8. What historical event is explored in Han Kang's novel *Human Acts*?

The Korean War.

The 1980 Gwangju killings.

The student protests of 1970.

The economic growth of South Korea.

9. How did the Swedish Academy characterize *Human Acts*?

A groundbreaking work of historical fiction, but lacking emotional depth.

A novel that gives voice to victims and approaches the genre of witness literature.

A controversial depiction of historical events that sparked public debate.

A raw and unfiltered account, yet ultimately too brutal for general readers.

10. Who is the other South Korean Nobel Prize winner mentioned in the article, and what prize did they receive?

Kim Dae-jung, Nobel Peace Prize.

Park Chung-hee, Nobel Economics Prize.

Moon Jae-in, Nobel Literature Prize (shared).

Ban Ki-moon, Nobel Humanitarian Award.

11. Which of the following is a criticism that the literature prize has long faced, according to Paragraph 12?

It often overlooks emerging literary talents.

It is perceived as too focused on European and North American writings.

The selection process lacks transparency.

It rarely awards non-fiction writers.

12. What fact is stated about women winning the Nobel Prize in Literature?

Han Kang is only the second woman to ever receive the award.

Women have won roughly half of all Nobel Literature Prizes.

Han Kang is the 18th woman to receive the award among more than 100 winners.

The prize has only been awarded to women in the last two decades.

13. Which past winner mentioned in the article received the Nobel Prize in Literature for creating 'new poetic expressions within the great American song tradition'?

W.B. Yeats

Ernest Hemingway

Bob Dylan

Gabriel Garcia Marquez

14. What was Han Kang reportedly doing when Mats Malm contacted her to inform her of the Nobel Prize?

She was giving a lecture at a university.

She had just finished supper with her son.

She was attending a literary conference.

She was working on her next novel.

15. What is the monetary value of the Nobel Prize mentioned in the article?

\$1.1 thousand.

\$110,000.

\$1.1 million.

\$11 million.